The universe is structured in terms of five types of real difference: the difference between God (*Vishnu*) and the individual soul, that between material objects and God, differences between individual souls, differences between individual souls and material objects, and differences between material objects. This universe is real and has no beginning. If it began, it would end. But it does not end. It is not imaginatively constructed due to misconception. Were it imagined, it would cease. But it does not cease. The *Advaitins* are mistaken in thinking that difference is unreal. Plurality is sustained and known by *Vishnu* and so it is real.

Further reading: Betty 1978; Gerow 1990; Sarma 2003; Sharma 1986

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Four Buddhist schools: the ***Vaibhashikas*** believe that we directly perceive objects outside the mind by the senses; the ***Sautrantikas*** say that we only infer the existence of mind-independent realities on the basis that different representative ideas figure in consciousness; the ***Vijnanavadins*** (***Yogacara***) deny that there are any physical objects outside consciousness and the ***Madhyamikas*** say that there are no unchanging essential natures and that there can be no complete and correct theories about what there is.

Four Noble Truths: the basic principles of the universal system of belief thought by Buddhists to have been discovered by *Siddhartha Gotama* (*Shakyamuni*), called the *Buddha* or 'Enlightened One' (c. 450–400 BCE).

Buddhists believe that the basic source of human discontent (***duhkha***) is a mistaken belief that one is an